CORTEX MOMENTUM // ONE-PAGE SECTOR READ

Firm power under bottlenecks

Gas turbines, grid equipment and firm capacity · as of October 2026 · a dated snapshot, not a forecast

When firm capacity and the equipment to build it are both scarce, the delivery date sets the price. Whoever can't hold a slot ends up paying for the delay.

THE SHORT VERSION

Firm power is scarce, and the equipment to build more of it is booked years out. So the market has stopped buying on lifetime cost. It buys on delivery date instead. The buyers who can lock a turbine slot, a transformer or a whole developer build first. Everyone else waits, and they pay for the wait in one of three ways: a premium for second-tier hardware, older plants kept running longer, or a share of grid costs that the largest loads no longer carry. If you sell into this market, a date you can stand behind is worth more than a lower price.

WHERE IT STANDS NOW

- **Turbines are still sold out, and reservations are turning into orders.** GE Vernova's Q3 release (SEC 8-K, Oct. 28, 2026) shows gas backlog plus slot reservations rising from 116 to 122 GW in the quarter. 13 GW of reservations converted to firm orders, and the company expects at least 130 GW by year-end.
- **Transformers are still short, and policy made it tighter.** Wood Mackenzie (Aug. 31, 2026) estimates a 2026 market shortage of about 15% for power transformers and 8% for substations. It expects the executive order restricting Chinese bulk-power equipment to make that worse.
- **Retirement overrides are legally weaker but still being issued.** On Sept. 11, 2026 the D.C. Circuit vacated DOE's first Section 202(c) order for Michigan's J.H. Campbell coal plant; later extension orders remain in effect, the current one through Nov. 14 (Michigan AG; Utility Dive). DOE issued another 90-day order for a different coal plant the same day, according to Inside Climate News. I found no confirmation yet of a rehearing petition or appeal.
- **TVA locked in its plan.** TVA's board approved the final 2026 IRP and a new data-center rate class on Aug. 20, 2026 (Sierra Club; WFAE). The final plan's exact coal retirement dates were not clear in what I could find.

WHAT IT MEANS IF YOU SELL INTO THIS

- **Sell certainty about dates.** If you can contractually stand behind a delivery date, that's your margin.
- **Sell into the gap between reservation and order.** Slot holders still need controls, fuel trains, interconnection gear, storage and permits sequenced from day one.
- **IPPs and behind-the-meter developers:** your competitor for the slot is often a balance sheet, not another developer.
- **Equipment and supply-chain companies:** watch terms before volume.
- **Exposed to retained coal or old peakers?** Extension orders are now legally contested.

> **The question I'd want answered first: If you lost your slot tomorrow, what would the next available date cost your buyer?**

WHAT TO WATCH

- **GE Vernova's Q4 2026 results (expected late January 2027):** does gas backlog plus reservations reach the guided 130 GW, and do conversions keep outpacing new reservations?
- **By March 31, 2027:** does DOE win rehearing or Supreme Court review of the Campbell ruling, or keep issuing 90-day 202(c) orders regardless?

If this bears on a decision you're making. A 30-minute call is for one thing: you bring the decision and its date, and we'll tell you what this read changes about it, and what it can't tell you. If the honest answer is that you don't need us, we'll say so. Book at cortexmomentum.com.

Cortex Momentum is an energy and cleantech market-intelligence advisory. The full read, with dated posts and sources: cortexmomentum.com/interconnect/threads/firm-power-bottlenecks.
Built from my published LinkedIn posts on this thread (April to October 2026), read against the filings and reporting cited above. Engagement is attention, not demand. Sources as of October 2026.